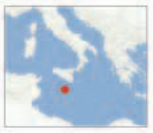


OTTOMAN EXPANSION

SIEGE OF MALTA



Date May 18–September 11, 1565
Forces Ottomans: c.180 ships; Knights of Malta: unknown
Losses Unknown

Location
Malta

In spring 1565 the Ottoman sultan Suleiman the Magnificent sent an expedition to capture Malta. The navy was commanded by Grand Admiral Piyale Pasha, aided by the Barbary corsair Turgut Reis and an Egyptian fleet under Uluç Ali. Some 40,000 soldiers were landed, including at least 6,000 janissaries, the Ottomans' crack troops. Cannon and gunpowder was shipped to the island in enormous quantities to besiege the Knights of Malta in their fortresses around the Grand Harbor. A relief force gathered in Sicily, but Spanish commander Don Garcia de Toledo knew his fleet was not strong enough to take on the Turks.

The first fortress to suffer the onslaught of the Turkish artillery was Fort St. Elmo at the entrance to Grand Harbor. The defenders held out valiantly for over a month, but Turgut Reis was killed during the siege. An attempt to attack St. Michael fort across the Grand Harbor failed, the Turkish ships blocked by a boom and blasted by cannon at water level.

In September the Ottomans admitted defeat and headed for home. The failed siege was the first significant reverse for the Ottomans in the Mediterranean.

Ottoman landings on Malta
The Ottoman army disembarks at Marsascirocco on the east coast of Malta south of Grand Harbor. The distinctive white headgear of the janissaries is conspicuous among the Turkish forces.

CREW PROFILE

RENAISSANCE GALLEY

16TH CENTURY

THE CREW OF A RENAISSANCE WAR GALLEY was typically assembled by a captain of high social status, appointed to his command by the state. On the other hand, a galley might also be the private venture of a mercenary or corsair. The captain did not necessarily have any nautical experience, relying on a team of experienced seamen to navigate and run the ship. Spanish royal galleys had a chaplain to look after the crew's spiritual welfare and a governor to maintain order and discipline. Although sailors and even oarsmen might at a push take part in combat, the fighting force was a separate body of men—a land army at sea that included gentleman volunteers, infantry, and specialist artillerymen.

CONVICTS AND SLAVES

Oarsmen made up the great majority of the crew. Some were free men, either signing on as volunteers or recruited by conscription—the latter common in Ottoman and Venetian fleets. But in the 16th century free oarsmen became increasingly rare, especially in the Spanish galley fleet, partly because they were too expensive to employ. Their place was taken by convicts or slaves. A spell in the Spanish galleys was the punishment for offences such as murder, robbery, blasphemy, rape, bigamy, and vagrancy, with sentences ranging from a few months to life.

CONDITIONS ON BOARD

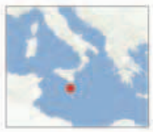
The slaves were usually prisoners of war, although more likely to have been seized by marauding privateers than taken prisoner in battle. Slaves in Christian galleys were chiefly Muslims, and vice versa. Free oarsmen were not chained and might have a weapon so they could fight if needed. But convicts and slaves were shackled to their benches. Life below deck on a crowded galley was miserable. A drum was beaten to give the rhythm for their strokes, but the lash was often used freely on any man thought to be slacking. An oarsman was a valuable item and intelligent captains kept their ships clean and the crew well fed. But more often sanitary arrangements were poor, ships stank, disease was rife, and gross ill-treatment common. Average life expectancy for a convict in a Spanish galley has been estimated at two years.



Venetian galley slave
As the Venice lost its possessions in the Ionian and Aegean to the Ottomans, there were fewer free men to recruit as oarsmen, so it relied more and more on slaves and convicts.

OTTOMAN EXPANSION

GOZO



Date July 15, 1570
Forces Knights of Malta: 4 galleys; Ottomans: 19 galliots
Losses Knights of Malta: 3 galleys captured; Ottomans: none

Location Off Cape Passaro, Sicily

In June 1570 the Knights of Malta sent four galleys under the command of French knight François de St Clément to join a Christian fleet in Sicily that had assembled for a campaign against the Turks. As things turned out, this campaign, did not come to fruition until the following year, when the fleet of the Holy League defeated the Ottomans at Lepanto. Since there was little prospect of action in Sicily, St. Clément decided to return to Malta, setting sail on the evening of July 14.

The following morning, some 20 miles (30 km) off the island of Gozo, the Knights' galleys were spotted by a squadron of galliots that Uluç Ali, recently appointed Beylerbey of Algiers, was taking to Constantinople. St. Clément turned back for Sicily with the Muslims in pursuit. The galliots were faster under oars than the large Maltese galleys, whose Muslim slave oarsmen had no incentive to hurry. Two galleys, *Santa Anna* and *San Giovanni*, were surrounded by galliots and boarded after heavy fighting that left their decks strewn with the dead and dying. The other two galleys reached the Sicilian coast, where St. Clément's flagship ran aground. As the knights fled, the slave oarsmen took over the galley and handed it over to Uluç Ali. Returning to Malta, St. Clément was condemned to death and his body thrown into the sea in a sack.